

“Start-ups don’t just require funds. They need mentorship and guidance as well!”

At Open Source India 2014, many tech start-ups wanted to understand how they could leverage open source technology. Well, for a start-up, or any other technology-oriented firm for that matter, getting the best tech solution at minimum cost is the way to go. But this is really not what we would focus on, in this article. While conversing with the owners of start-ups who were present at OSI Days 2014, we understood that one of the biggest issues was generating funds to move ahead in the game. Yes, this is pretty much an issue for almost every start-up, particularly in a country like India, where the start-up ecosystem is still in its infancy. As they say, if there is a problem, there is a solution too. As we all know, venture capitalists do come to the rescue of such start-ups, looking to be funded. But the road leading to a VC invariably involves a bumpy ride.

In a bid to understand the entire process of reaching out to a VC and how to arrange funds, **Diksha P Gupta** from *Open Source For You* spoke to **Sushanto Mitra, founder and CEO, Lead Angels**, an alumni-focused angel network, and discussed several issues that hamper young entrepreneurs. Read on...



Sushanto Mitra, founder and CEO, Lead Angels

Q What are the areas in which start-ups need help and how does Lead Angels pitch in?

A. Before I answer that, I would like to share a bit about our origin. In the year 2000, I had set up a consulting firm, helping the early-stage companies to raise money. I continued doing that till 2007, when I joined IIT Bombay as the CEO of its business incubator called SINE. It was a very interesting stint as I was coming across very early-stage ideas and incubating them. But the fact remains that in academic institutions, even though there are very bright people, the exposure to business is very limited. Unfortunately, even today, most of these academic

institutions are not able to interact with the outside world; therefore, the world beyond the campus walls doesn't get to know what exciting ideas are brewing inside. Students only get a hang of the real world when they move out, which is why a lot of alumni of various institutions want to give back to their institutes. They want to invest in interesting ideas with the aim of giving back in some way and also because they are more comfortable in their own alma mater.

There is a level of credibility and comfort already established when it comes to the alumni. So that is the origin of Lead Angels. We are an alumni-focused angel network, with which